

Using modals verbs to express certainty

GRAMMAR

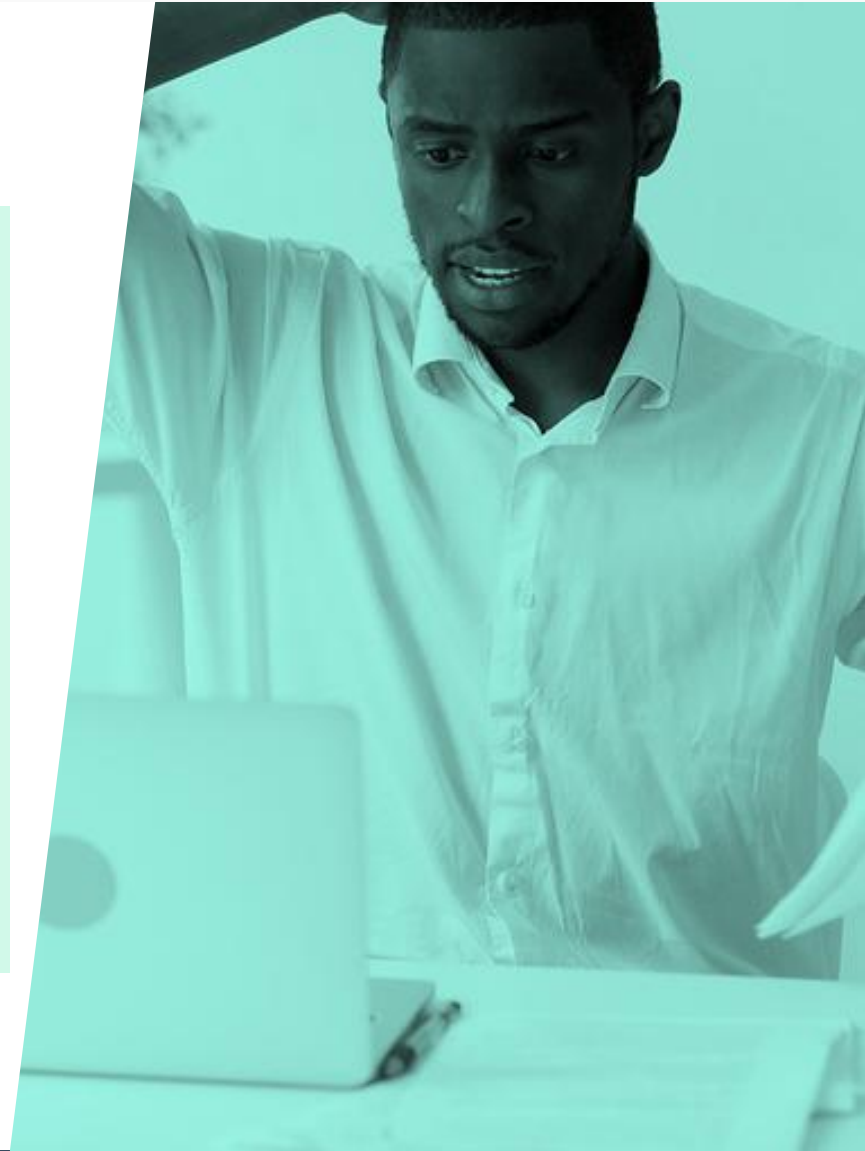
**NUMBER
EN BE 3119G**

LANGUAGE
English



Goals

- Can provide a simple explanation of modals of deduction and their uses, with examples.
- Can accurately select the correct modals of deduction for a range of straightforward sentences.





Go through this lesson and return to check if you still feel the percentages are correct.



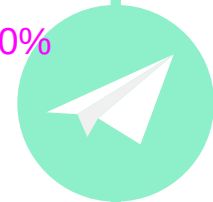
100%

John must really hate his job. He has so many problems there that he **might** quit soon. He **can't** be happy at all.

kwit

100%

20%



quite (long i) kwai-t





Preview and warm-up

In this lesson, you are going to learn **modals of deduction** to express **how certain you are about something**.

They are ~~doing~~ (having) a meeting. It seems they are not



They **must** be disagreeing about something.



Must



- Let's first learn how to **express certainty using modal verbs**.
- When you are very sure about something, you can use **must** to talk about it.
- These kinds of sentences are not necessarily facts, but are details that we are very sure about based on the information we have.

Information	Opinion
Your friend was at work all day	She must be tired.
You can't find your mug at work	It must be at home.
Your colleague is absent from a meeting	She must be ill.

He must be at home because the company is closed today.





Must

- In the previous slide, every example was simply ***must + be + adjective***. It is possible to create different sentences.
- Look at the following examples that are built using ***must + verb***:

She must love her job.

They must need something to eat.

My mug must be in the dishwasher.

The printer must be out of paper.

He must like his boss.

She must live close to her work.





Can't

- When we are using modals of deduction, the opposite of must is can't.
- We use **can't** when we are sure something is not possible.
- We use can't + be + adjective or can't + verb.

Information	Opinion
Monica is absent today	She can't be feeling well.
We've run out of paper	That can't be true! We bought a lot last week.
We're short of tea.	We can't be short of tea – someone must be taking it home with them.
I can't get my computer to work.	It can't be plugged in.

What can't happen today for you?

I can't drink coffee because I don't have any at home.



Fill in the gaps

Fill in the gaps with the verbs below.

be

live

be

like

be

1. I can't get the printer to work, it must be out of paper.
2. Susan is never late to work, she must live close to the office.
3. John can't like his colleagues much – he never socialises with them. *so-shal-aiz-iz*
4. My stapler can't be missing again – it's ridiculous! *stay-pler*
5. Bernice must be working late – she's always here till after 8pm.





Fill in the gaps

Fill in the gaps with *must* or *can't*.



I can't hear anything. My headphones _____ be plugged in.



The audio and video quality are poor. The internet connection _____ be bad.



Dave _____ really like his boss, they go out for drinks every Friday.



We seem to be short on pens but I _____ believe it – I bought loads recently.



Speaking

The woman in front
of the counter must buy something.



Look at the picture and make deductions about what you can see using
must and can't.

The
woman
in front
of the
window
can't be



The man behind
the counter must
be... busy.



The woman can't
be...



May, might and could

- We use *may, might* and *could* when we have an opinion, but we are not sure if we are correct.

possibility = certainty
able to be true/happen = how sure about smth we are

My wallet is missing!	It might be in your car. (It must be in the car.)
Paul's absent today.	He could be taking care of his daughter.
We've run out of paper.	There may be some more in the cupboard.
We're short of chocolate biscuits.	You might find some in Charles' office.



Modals of deduction

- Look at some more examples using **modals of deduction** here.

Sure negative	Not sure	Sure positive
It can't be broken – it's new!	It might be broken.	It must be broken if it won't work.
He can't like working late.	He may like working late.	He must like working late.
The printer can't be out of paper.	The printer could be out of paper.	The printer must be out of paper.



Modal verbs in the past

eat- present (1st form)
ate- past (2nd form)

play
played
nlaved

- You can use these words in different tenses as well but the structure changes slightly.
- To talk about the **past** we use modal verb + have + past participle
3rd form of verb
par-TI-si-pl

modal verb	have	past participle
They must	have	been busy.
He might	have	gone to bed.
She may	have	sent the report yesterday.
He can't	have	paid his bills.
They mightn't	have	seen it yet.



Unscramble

A+

might have
of the biscuits.
Amira
eaten all

having connection
be
Kyle may
problems.



this week.
short of time
could be
Alice



Make deductions using *might*, *may* and *could*

1. I think your laptop is missing.

→ Your laptop might be missing.

2. I think Dave has taken your laptop.

→ Dave might have taken your laptop. ✓

3. Maybe the connection is bad.

→ _____

4. I think Ella was stuck in traffic.

→ _____

5. Rachel thinks we are short of stationery.

→ _____



Say what you think has happened using *might*, *may* and *could*

My mobile phone is missing.

I can't see my colleague on a video call.

We have run out of chocolate biscuits.

We can't get this new software to work.



Speaking

Look at these pictures and make deductions about them.



It must be a boring meeting.



He might be very tired.



Game



Tell your classmates something that happened to you and let them guess why

I walked into my office at 10am one day and it was completely empty.

You might work from home.

It must have been a Sunday.



Reflect on the goals

check the feedback for a list of past participle verbs and practice using them in modals of deduction sentences.

Go back to the second slide of the lesson and check if you have achieved all the goals of the lesson.

yes

no





Reflect on this lesson

Think about everything you have seen in this lesson.
What were the most difficult activities or words? The easiest?



If you have time, go over
the most difficult slides again



Answer key

Exercise p. 8

1. be, 2. live, 3. like, 4. be, 5. be

Exercise p. 9

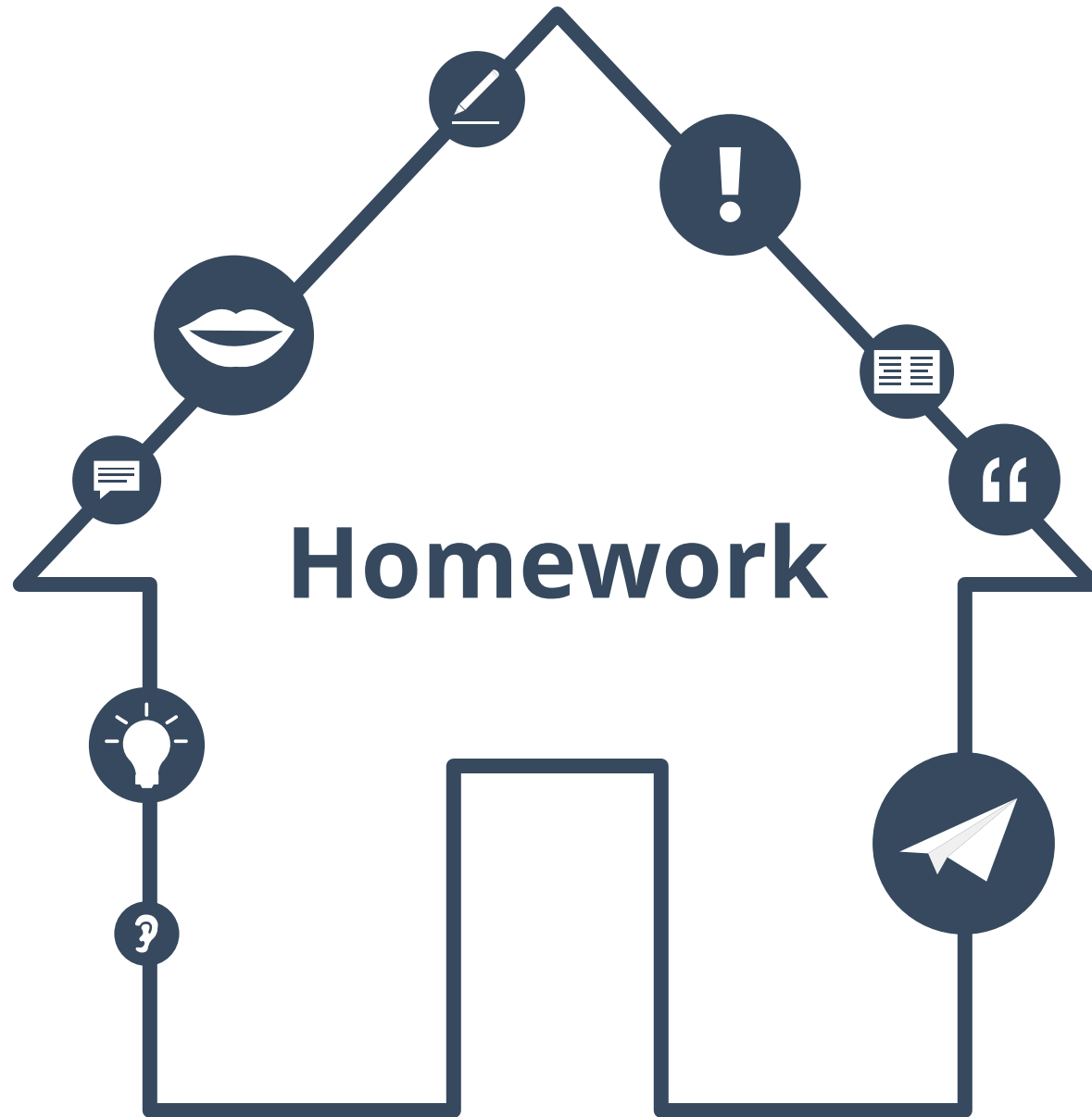
can't, must, must, can't

Exercise p. 13

Amira might have eaten all the biscuits. Kyle may be having connection problems. Alice could be short of time this week.

Exercise p. 14

2. Dave may/might/could have taken your laptop. 3. The connection may/might/could be bad. 4. Ella may/might/could have been stuck in traffic. 5. Rachel thinks we may/might/could be short of stationery.





Fill in the gaps with the words on the right

Herbert is having a really bad day at work. First, he can't get his computer to work – he thinks it _____ be broken, but he's not sure. Then, he sees that his favourite cup is missing from his desk – he's sure his colleague Alex _____ have taken it because he does it nearly every day. He goes to the kitchen to make some toast but he sees that there is no bread. He thinks, 'We _____ have run out already, I bought some yesterday. Alex _____ have eaten it, or maybe it was Sue. I'll never know for sure.'

must

might

can't

could



Try to write a similar short story to the one on p. 22 using your own ideas and the modals of deduction. Imagine a really bad day at work.

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Homework answer key

Exercise p. 22

might/could, must, can't, might/could



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